

Japan: April Trade: Crude Oil Import Unit Price Surges while Import Volume Plunges. Stable LNG Import Price

BOTTOM LINE: April export volume maintained a similar pace of increase as the January–March average, at +3.4% yoy (+3.6% in Jan–Mar). However, on a seasonally adjusted mom basis (our calculation), volume declined by –2.9% in April (Jan–Mar quarter: +3.9% qoq). Regarding crude oil imports, the import unit price in yen terms rose by 57% in April compared to February, before the Middle East conflict, while import volume decreased by 63.7% yoy. Meanwhile, natural gas imports also decreased by 20.6% yoy, but the unit price in yen terms rose by only 4% compared to February.

Yuriko Tanaka
+81(3)4587-9964 |
yuriko.tanaka@gs.com
Goldman Sachs Japan Co., Ltd.

JP MAP:

Export value growth: +16 (relevance: 4; surprise: +4)

KEY NUMBERS:

- Trade Balance: April: +¥301.9 bn vs. GS forecast: –¥71.5 bn, BBG consensus: –¥72.5 bn, April 2025: –¥149.5 bn
- Export Value (yoy): April: +14.8% vs. GS forecast: +10.0%, BBG consensus: +9.0%, March: +11.5%
- Import Value (yoy): April: +9.7% vs. GS forecast: +9.0%, BBG consensus: +8.5%, March: +10.9%
- Export Volume (yoy): April: +3.4%, March: +3.6%,
- Import Volume (yoy): April: –3.4%, March: +2.4%

MAIN POINTS:

Trade data for April show that export value posted double-digit growth for the second consecutive month, at +14.8% yoy. Import value maintained a similar pace of increase to March (+10.9%), at +9.7% yoy. As a result, the trade balance swung to a surplus of +¥301.9 bn, from a small deficit of –¥149.5 bn in April of last year.

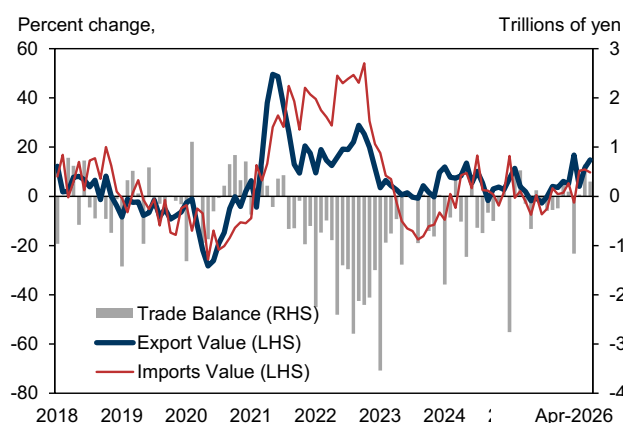
Export volume maintained a similar pace of increase in April as the January–March average of +3.6%, at +3.4% yoy. However, on a seasonally adjusted mom basis (our calculation), volume declined by –2.9% mom in April (Jan–Mar quarter: +3.9% qoq). While export volume to the US and Europe increased sharply yoy, exports to Asia slowed.

Regarding crude oil imports, a point of concern since the worsening of the situation in the Middle East, the unit price calculated from import value and volume had not yet risen significantly as of March. However, prices rose sharply in April to ¥16,121/bl

(March: ¥10,763/bl), or US\$101.4/bl (March: US\$68.7/bl) in US dollar terms. This represents a sharp rise of +57% and +54%, respectively, compared to February (pre-conflict). On a yoy basis, prices turned to an increase of +38% and +28% (they were down -10% yoy in March). Crude oil import volume dropped by -63.7% yoy.

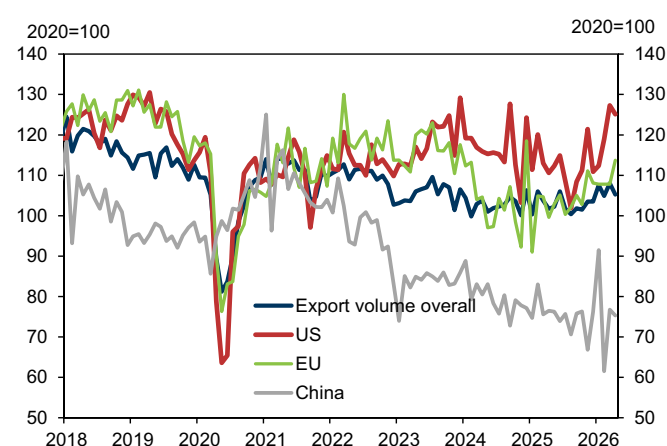
On the other hand, the import unit price for natural gas rose by only 4% from February to ¥1,829/mmbtu, and in dollar terms, rose by only 2% to US\$11.5/mmbtu from US\$11.3 in February. Import volume was 4269 thousand tons in total, and decreased by -20.6% yoy. While natural gas imports from the Middle East decreased by 76% yoy to 139 thousand tons, imports from Russia increased by 30% yoy to 456 thousand tons.

Exhibit 1: Exports, Imports and Trade Balance



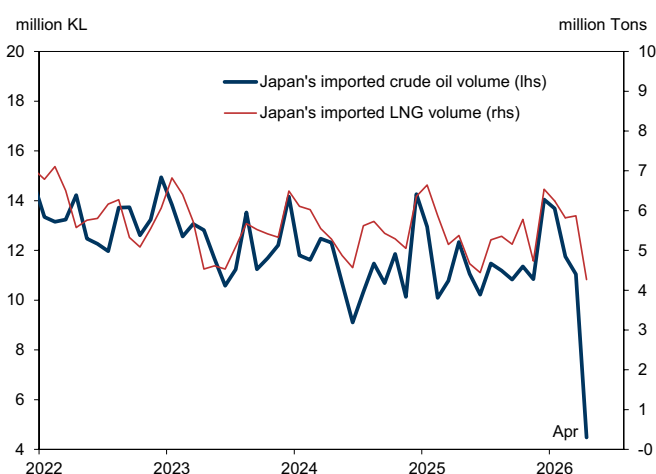
Source: Ministry of Finance

Exhibit 2: Export Volume by Region (Seasonally Adjusted Level)



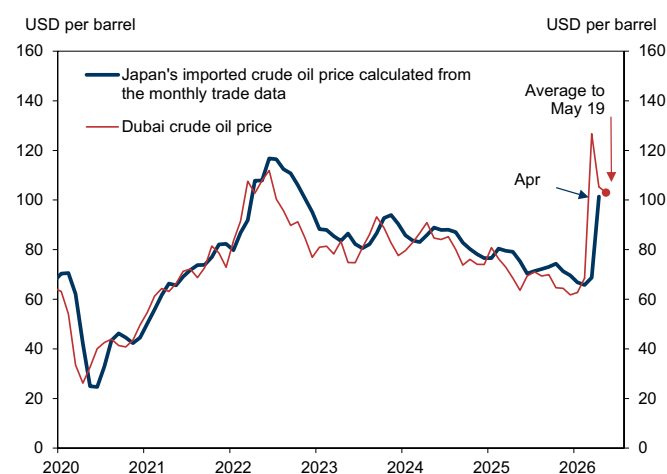
Source: MOF

Exhibit 3: Japan's Imported Crude Oil and LNG Volume

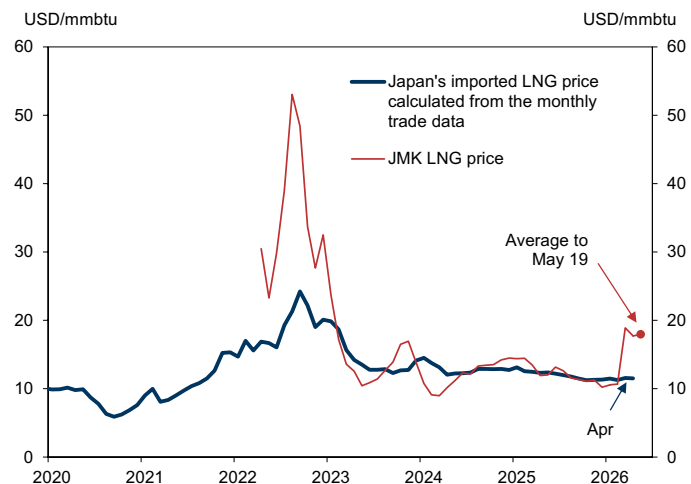


Source: MOF

Exhibit 4: Japan's Imported Oil Price and Dubai Oil Price



Source: MOF, Datastream, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 5: Japan's Imported LNG Price and JMK LNG Price

Source: MOF, Bloomberg, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The Japan Economics Team

Akira Otani

+81(3)4587-9960
akira.otani@gs.com
Goldman Sachs Japan Co., Ltd.

Tomohiro Ota

+81(3)4587-9984
tomohiro.ota@gs.com
Goldman Sachs Japan Co., Ltd.

Yuriko Tanaka

+81(3)4587-9964
yuriko.tanaka@gs.com
Goldman Sachs Japan Co., Ltd.

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Contributing Authors: Yuriko Tanaka Goldman Sachs Japan Co., Ltd..

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